

# Podium AI Hackathon Theme

## THE CHALLENGE

Build an AI agent that can autonomously operate a real business.

Not assist. Not advice. Operate.

Your agent is the one making decisions — which customers to pursue, what to charge, how to handle a cancellation, when to hire, whether to run a promotion. A human might check in, but the business runs whether they do or not.

## WHAT WE MEAN BY "RUN A BUSINESS"

Think about what it actually takes to operate a simple business. Take a lawn care company:

Someone has to find customers — maybe that means door-knocking, maybe it means responding to leads on a website, maybe it means asking existing customers for referrals. Someone has to qualify those customers — what's the lot size, how often do they want service, are they in the service area? Someone has to set prices that are competitive but profitable. Someone has to schedule the work across crews and geography so you're not driving 40 minutes between jobs. Someone has to buy equipment and supplies — and decide when the old mower isn't worth repairing anymore. Someone has to hire and manage workers — figure out when you need another crew, who's reliable, who handles the difficult customers well. Someone has to deal with problems — the customer who says you scalped their lawn, the rainy day that blows up your schedule, the crew member who no-shows. And someone has to think about the business — are we profitable? Should we add a new service? Are we losing customers, and why?

That's a lot. And it's different for every business. A food truck has inventory and menu decisions but no recurring customers. A tutoring center has complex matching (student to tutor to subject to schedule) but no physical logistics. A dog walking service is all about trust and reliability and route optimization.

Your job is to pick a business, understand what it really takes to run it, and then build an agent that handles a meaningful part of that — autonomously.

## HOW YOU'LL BE JUDGED

### WHAT YOU BUILD

The working agent you demo. Judges will interact with it live. They'll throw curveballs at it. They'll want to see it make real decisions — not follow scripts, not parrot responses, not require a human to hold its hand.

You do not need to build everything. In fact, trying to build everything is a trap. Pick the part of the business where an autonomous agent is most interesting, most valuable, or most differentiated — and go deep. That might be customer interactions. It might be operational optimization. It might be something you discover along the way that nobody else thought of.

A tight, polished agent that handles one workflow with genuine autonomy will always beat a sprawling agent that does twelve things shallowly.

### CRITERIA (ORDERED BY WEIGHT)

- Autonomy — Does the agent operate independently? Does it make decisions, handle full workflows end-to-end, and initiate actions without being prompted? Could you walk away and the business keeps running?
- Business Value — Does this solve a real problem a real business owner has? Is the agent doing something meaningfully useful — not just technically impressive, but actually valuable?
- Technical Execution — How ambitious and well-built is the engineering? Did the team tackle hard problems — multi-step reasoning, state management, tool use, real-time adaptation?
- Demo & Storytelling — Did the demo land? Was the agent's capability clearly communicated? Did the team demonstrate a deep understanding of the business they chose?

## PICKING YOUR BUSINESS

Choose a simple, familiar business. Some starting points:

- Dog walking service
- House cleaning service
- Lawn care company
- Auto detailing shop
- ...or *pitch your own*

Don't just pick what sounds fun — pick what you understand. The teams that do well will be the ones who know the real pain points of the business they choose. If you've ever waited tables,

build a restaurant agent. If you've hired contractors, build a home services agent. Domain knowledge is a cheat code.

As you choose, think about what makes your business interesting as an AI problem. Every business has a mix of:

- Customer-facing work — acquiring, communicating with, and retaining customers
- Operational decisions — scheduling, routing, resource allocation, staffing
- Strategic thinking — pricing, promotions, service mix, market positioning
- Problem-solving — handling complaints, adapting to disruptions, managing risk

You don't need to cover all of these. But knowing which ones matter most for *your* business will help you decide where to focus your build.

## TIPS

1. Start with the problem, not the tech. Know who the customer is and what pain you're removing. If we can't immediately feel the problem, the solution won't land.
2. Go deep, not wide. Pick one or two workflows and make them genuinely autonomous. Clear thinking shows up in the product.
3. Stress-test before the judges do. What happens when three customers book the same slot? When a supplier falls through? When someone leaves a brutal review? Find the breaking points early.
4. Think about what autonomy actually requires. Your agent needs memory, judgment, and initiative. These are hard problems — solving even one of them well is impressive.
5. Take risks. Build something that hasn't been built before. The category awards exist to recognize teams that swing big, even if the execution isn't flawless.

## Anthropic + Cursor Credits

- Credits - \$250 Claude Code per team; \$100 Cursor per individual
- Details for access have been sent via email
- If you run out of Cursor credits, text us at 712-220-7631
- Any spend beyond these limits is covered by participants

## SUBMIT YOUR PROJECT

Submit details about your project **by 4pm** using [this google form](#).